

The Body Keeps the Score by Bessel van der Kolk.

How Trauma Lives in the Body, Not Just the Mind

Many people try to move on from painful experiences
by telling themselves they're fine.
By staying busy.
By pushing forward without looking back.

But what happens
when the body doesn't get the message?

In *The Body Keeps the Score*, Bessel van der Kolk explores a powerful reality:
**even when the mind understands that the danger has passed,
the body may still be living as if it hasn't.**

This book helps explain why people can feel anxious, tense, disconnected, or unsafe
without fully knowing why —
and why true healing often requires more than insight, logic, or willpower.

1. Trauma Is an Experience, Not an Event

One of the central ideas of this book
is that trauma is not defined by what happened,
but by **how the nervous system experienced it.**

Two people can live through the same event.
One processes it and moves forward.
The other carries it for years.

Trauma occurs when an experience overwhelms the brain's ability
to process, organize, and integrate what is happening.

Instead of becoming part of the past,
the experience remains active in the present —
stored not as a story,
but as sensation, emotion, and instinct.

This is why trauma often shows up as:

- Panic without a clear trigger
- Emotional numbness or detachment

- Chronic muscle tension
- Sudden reactions that feel confusing or excessive

These are not personality traits.
They are **unfinished survival responses**.

2. What Trauma Does to the Brain

Van der Kolk explains that during trauma, the brain reorganizes itself around survival.

The rational, thinking part of the brain — responsible for language, reflection, and perspective — becomes less active.

The survival brain takes control.

This is why traumatized people often say:
“I know I’m safe... but I don’t feel safe.”

Their body is responding to a memory as if it were a present-day threat.

Trauma keeps the nervous system locked in fight, flight, or freeze, even long after the danger has ended.

3. Why Talking Alone Is Often Not Enough

Traditional therapy often assumes that understanding leads to healing.

But van der Kolk shows that **trauma lives below words**.

You can explain your past in great detail and still feel trapped in anxiety, shame, or hypervigilance.

That’s because trauma is stored in the body:

- In breathing patterns
- In posture and muscle tone
- In heart rate and digestion

- In automatic emotional reactions

Talking can help create meaning.
But **regulation must come first**.

Without a sense of bodily safety,
the nervous system remains on guard —
and insight alone cannot resolve that.

4. The Body as the Path to Healing

One of the most hopeful messages of the book
is that the same body that holds trauma
can also become the path to recovery.

Van der Kolk describes approaches that help people:

- Reconnect with bodily sensations
- Restore a sense of safety and control
- Learn to regulate their nervous system

These include:

- Yoga and mindful movement
- Breath-based practices
- EMDR
- Somatic therapies

These methods work not by forcing memories away,
but by teaching the body
that the present moment is different from the past.

That the danger is over.

5. Reclaiming Agency and Presence

Trauma takes away choice.
It causes the body to react automatically,
without permission.

Healing is the gradual process of **giving choice back**.

As people reconnect with their bodies,
they learn to notice sensations without panic.
They stay present instead of dissociating.
They regain the ability to pause, choose, and respond.

This restoration of agency
is often more important than symptom reduction.

It allows people to feel alive again,
not just functional.

6. Trauma Is More Common Than We Think

Van der Kolk emphasizes that trauma is not rare
and it is not a personal failure.

Many people carry trauma from:

- Childhood experiences
- Emotional neglect
- Relationships
- Medical events
- Chronic stress

Seeing trauma through a compassionate lens
changes how we relate to ourselves
and how we respond to others.

It replaces judgment with understanding.

Final Takeaways

The Body Keeps the Score teaches us that:

- Trauma is stored in the nervous system
- The body remembers what the mind forgets
- Healing requires safety, not force
- Regulation comes before insight
- The body can learn to feel safe again

You are not broken.
Your body learned to survive.

And with the right support,
it can learn something new.

So the question is not,
“What’s wrong with me?”
but rather,
“What did my body learn — and how can I help it unlearn?”

Because healing is not about forcing the body to forget.
It’s about teaching it — patiently and repeatedly —
that **the present is safe.**